were with the Chinese. There is little doubt that Tawang was indeed the subject of intense discussion. Eventually, in exchange for the weapons and ammunition required by the Tibetans (5,000 Lee Enfield Rifles and 500,000 rounds of ammunition), Lonchen Shatra was authorized by the Dalai Lama to agree to the boundary alignment suggested by McMahon. This secret deal on Tawang could hardly be discussed with the Chinese.

At the time, China's Qing Dynasty had collapsed and the Chinese had been expelled even from Eastern Tibet. The drawing up of the Indo-Tibetan frontier was of little interest to China. The subsequent refusal to ratify the treaty had everything to do with the Inner and Outer boundaries between Tibet and China, and nothing to do with the McMahon Line. Sardar Patel, who had warned Nehru about this in his letter, had anticipated that the Chinese would go back on all existing treaties between the Tibetans and British India. The subsequent interpretation of the Indo-Tibet boundary by Mao's Communist China was dictated purely by China's perceived strategic requirements. Once the Chinese had Nehru trapped with the lofty idealism of the Panchsheel Agreement, the Indo-China border dispute became the focal point and within four years Tibet's annexation was put on the back burner.

Blaming Nehru's Forward Policy for the conflict is to view the situation with blinkered glasses. If anything, the failure was in not implementing it forcefully enough. Indian troops, especially the paramilitary and police forces, had every right to be in the area that India was seriously claiming as its territory. Until 1947, troops from the Kashmir State Forces regularly visited the Aksai Chin area and even maintained a post at Shahidula. Post Independence the practice was discontinued. End result: Mao's Communist China simply took over the entire region and India found out about it in 1957. Critics claim Aksai Chin was never really a part of Kashmir, and it was 'gifted' to the maharaja by the surveyor Johnson, who was considered to be a rogue. Even if that point was ceded, the question that begs to be asked is what did China (or even Tibet or Sinkiang for that matter) have to do with it? The absence of Indian posts in the Aksai Chin made it low hanging fruit. Militarily, the Chinese needed it; so they simply took it!

The Indian failure perhaps lay in putting too much trust in the 'legal' position, rather than looking at the developing situation on the ground. China's practice of 'occupying the last ridge from the China side and creeping up on the first ridge on the Indian' side meant the borders and